Dhananjaya Pandita

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Beloved Servant of Nityananda

Pandita Dhananjaya is one of the twelve gopalas, the eternal companions of Nityananda Prabhu. In the two lists of the gopalas given by one of the biographies his name stands sixth, and in the royal assembly of the Vaishnavas of the whole world — the Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha — he, like the other eleven, is given a seat of honour.

Both great biographers of Mahaprabhu have spoken of him. Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, who called himself the last servant of Nityananda, writes in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata”:

“Dhananjaya Pandita was an extraordinary devotee. Nityananda always dwelt in his heart.” (CB, Antya 5.733)[1]

Krishnadasa Kaviraja Goswami, counting the branches of Nityananda's tree in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita,” adds:

“Pandita Dhananjaya is the beloved servant of Sri Nityananda. He was wholly renounced and constantly absorbed in feelings of love for Krishna.” (CC, Adi 11.31)

His story begins with these two testimonies, and they already hold what matters most: Nityananda lives in his heart, and he himself is Nityananda's renounced servant, full of love for Krishna. Everything else in his life simply unfolds these two lines.

Vasudama

Who he is in Krishna's eternal pastimes is revealed by Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika”:

“He who was formerly called Sudama is now Thakura Sundara; and the friend Vasudama is Pandita Sri Dhananjaya.” (GGD 127)

In Vraja, then, he is Vasudama, a friend (sakha) of Krishna among the cowherd boys; and in the same verse stands Sundarananda, another gopala of Nityananda's circle.[2]

Origin and Family

Accounts of his birthplace and parents differ.

According to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” Dhananjaya was born in the village of Jaragrama in the district of Chittagong (Chattagrama) on the shukla-panchami of the month of Chaitra, 1485. His father is named as Shripati Bandyopadhyaya and his mother as Kalindi Devi. This view is also held by Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura in his “Anubhashya.” It is said, too, that from Jaragrama he later established the service of Deities in Shitalagrama and in the village of Sanchra-Panchra.[3]

The “Gauranga-madhuri” says otherwise: his birthplace was the village of Sivan-Muluk near Bolpur in the district of Birbhum, his father Adideva Vachaspati, his mother Dayamayi. Curiously, Muluk near Bolpur is the shripata of his nephew Ramakanai.

On one point both books agree: Dhananjaya was married, and his wife's name was Haripriya. He married very young. His devotion to Tulasi is also remembered: three times a day he would fall prostrate before Tulasi Devi.

He had no children and left no line of descendants. His brother was Sri Sanjaya,[4] and Sanjaya's son was Sri Ramakanai Thakura.

Renunciation

Soon after his marriage Dhananjaya set out on pilgrimage. His father was a man of means and gave his son money for the road. But Dhananjaya gave it all to Mahaprabhu, keeping for himself only a begging pot. The Vaishnavas remembered this deed, and Devakinandana glorifies him in his "Vaishnava-vandana":

"I praise the renunciant Pandita Dhananjaya, sporting [in bhava]: giving everything to the Lord, he took a pot in his hand." ("Vaishnava-vandana" of Devakinandana, 118)

The Sanskrit "Vaishnava-vandana" ascribed to Srila Jiva Goswami says the same: the generous pandita gave all he had to the Lord and took for himself only a pot for alms and a loincloth.

It is for this that the Vaishnavas remember him. In a single gesture complete renunciation and the joy of service came together: to give the Lord everything his father had given him and to walk away with nothing but a beggar's pot.

Sankirtana and the Road to Vrindavana

Tradition holds that Dhananjaya took part in Mahaprabhu's sankirtana in Navadvipa and spent several days in it.[5] He then returned to Shitalagrama and from there set out for Vrindavana.[6]

On the way he stayed for a time in the village of Sanchra-Panchra, three kroshas south of the present Memari station.[7] When he left for Vrindavana, he entrusted the service of the Deity to a disciple who had been his companion on the road. That is why people call this village too "Dhananjaya's pata." Today nothing of him remains in Sanchra-Panchra — not even the temple.

Jalandi and Shitalagrama

Returning from Vrindavana, Dhananjaya served the Deity in the village of Jalandi, and then came back to Shitalagrama, where he established the service of Sri Gauranga.[8]

Shitalagrama became his principal shripata. The village lies in the district of Bardhaman, in Mangalkot thana (Kaichar post office). From Bardhaman a narrow-gauge line runs to Katwa; nine miles from Katwa is Kaichar station, and the village is about a mile north-east of it.[9]

At first the temple was a hut with mud walls. Long ago the Malliks, zamindars of the village of "Bazarban Kabashi," built the Deity a brick house, but in time it too collapsed; only its foundation now remains.[10] In the room with the western door the Deities whom Dhananjaya himself served are worshipped to this day: Gopinatha, Sri Sri Nitai-Gaura and Damodara, a shalagrama-shila.

Dhananjaya's disciple Sri Jivana Krishna (also called Jiva Krishna) installed the ancient Deity of Sri Shyamasundara, who now resides in the house of Sri Gopala Raya Chaudhuri.

The shripatas of his kin are also known. Sanjaya lived in the village of Jalandi (Lokanagar post office), about five kroshas east of Bardhaman; Sri Radha-Govinda are served there.[11] The shripata of Ramakanai Thakura is the village of Muluk, very close to present-day Bolpur.

Preaching and Nityananda's Company

As Nityananda's companion, Dhananjaya shared His labours in Gauda. According to the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," he was among Nityananda's companions at the chida-dadhi festival in Panihati, when Raghunatha Dasa fed everyone flat rice with yogurt:

“Dhananjaya, Jagadisha, Parameshvara Dasa, Mahesha, Gauridasa and Hoda Krishnadasa.” (CC, Antya 6.62)

His name also appears in the list of Nityananda's servants in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Antya 5) — the very verse quoted above — and in the Bengali “First Vandana,” which is ascribed to Vrindavana Dasa and repeats that list.

There is also a tradition that in the neighbourhood of Shitalagrama he turned many robbers and godless men to devotion.[12]

Departure and Samadhi

Dhananjaya Pandita left this world on the shukla-ashtami of the month of Kartika. In our calendar the day of his departure is observed on Goshthashtami (Gopashtami), the shukla-ashtami of the month of Damodara. In Shitalagrama there is also a yearly festival in his memory, when the Deities are carried out to a field not far from the temple.[13]

His samadhi too is in Shitalagrama: it is the tulasi-vedi to the left of the temple entrance. The service there is carried on by the descendants of his disciple.[14]

1. One biography gives this verse as CB 3.5.773; in our text of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” it is Antya 5.733.

2. In the “Gopala-nirnaya,” an insertion made by a later compiler into the same “First Vandana” (on which see below), Vasudama is named as Kamalakara, not Dhananjaya; this differs from the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika,” and Dhananjaya himself is not mentioned in the insertion.

3. According to one biography, the “accepted view” is that he was born in Shitalagrama; the same account confuses Jaragrama and Shitalagrama, giving the name Shitalagrama to a place in Chattagrama known as Sanchada-Panchada. Other accounts make Shitalagrama Dhananjaya's principal shripata, not his birthplace.

4. Some hold that Sanjaya was his disciple rather than his brother.

5. According to another biography, he was “for some time” in the sankirtana party led by the Lord.

6. According to another biography, he went straight from the sankirtana party to Vrindavana.

7. The distance is given differently: six miles south of Memari station; or two miles south of Satdeul-Tajapur, which is four miles from Memari station. According to one biography, Sanchra and Panchra are two separate places, and he had homes (shripatas) in Sanchra, in Panchra and in Jalandi.

8. According to another account, on returning from Vrindavana to Shitala he installed the Deity of Gaurasundara in the temple. According to yet another, he installed the Deity in Jalandi, and the Deities of that temple are Gopinatha, Nitai-Gaura and the shalagrama-shila Damodara; two other biographies place these Deities in Shitalagrama.

9. According to another biography, the village is a mile north of Kaichar station, and the station nine miles west of Katwa.

10. According to one account, the temple has stood ruined and abandoned for sixty-five years, and the zamindars are said to be “of Bazaravana Kaba.”

11. According to another biography, Jalandi is about ten miles east of Bardhaman.

12. Only one biography records this tradition, and only it says that Nityananda delivered him as “the most fallen” of His dear devotees. The text at this point seems to be mixed with the account of another companion of Nityananda; the other biographies have nothing of the kind. An eternal associate of the Lord is never fallen; if such words are applied to Dhananjaya, they express only a Vaishnava's humility.

13. According to one biography this festival is held in the middle of the month of Magha, according to another in January. Perhaps Shitalagrama celebrates a day other than that of his departure.

14. Two other biographies say: the descendants of his disciples. One account even says that the service is carried on by “the descendants of Pandita Dhananjaya,” but this contradicts the report that he left no line of descendants.